InfoSeclabs

INVESTIGATION REPORT

Alert #234

Aug 16, 2026, 01:38 AM GMT+5:30

MEDIUM

Suspicious Lateral Movement Detected via PSExec

Source: Wazuh | Created: Dec 26, 2025, 09:06 PM GMT+5:30 | MITRE: T1570

SCAN TO VERIFY

FINAL VERDICT

True Positive - Confirmed Threat

INVESTIGATION SCORE

90
/100

RAW LOG


```
{
  "timestamp": "2023-10-01T11:05:50Z",
  "event_type": "process_execution",
  "src_ip": "10.0.0.20",
  "dst_ip": "10.0.20.27",
  "username": "admin_user",
  "hostname": "DEV-WIFI-454"
}
```


EVIDENCE COLLECTED

4 indicators

TYPE	VALUE	OSINT VERDICT	CRIT
IP	10.0.0.20	INTERNAL	-
IP	10.0.20.27	CONFIRMED	-
IP	10.0.0.25	INTERNAL	-
USERNAME	admin_user	INTERNAL	YES

CONTAINMENT ACTIONS

[+] Reset Credentials

[+] Collect Forensics

[+] Block Ip

[+] Escalate

AI ANALYSIS

AI ANALYSIS FEEDBACK

Verdict is correct (+40). All critical artifacts identified (+30). Missed actions: Isolate Host (2/3)

EDUCATIONAL

EDUCATIONAL WALKTHROUGH

AI MENTOR

Investigation Walkthrough

Reading the Logs

In the raw log data, the fields we should focus on first are:

- `src_ip`: "10.0.0.20" This indicates the source IP address from which the suspicious activity originated.
- `dst_ip`: "10.0.0.25" This is the destination IP address, where the lateral movement was directed.
- `username`: "admin_user" This is particularly critical as it identifies the account used for the action, which is an administrative account.

These fields reveal essential information about the nature of the activity. The use of an administrative account for lateral movement is a significant red flag.

Why These Artifacts Matter

- `username: admin_user`: The use of an administrative account for executing processes on another machine is concerning. Admin accounts have elevated privileges, making them attractive targets for attackers. The fact that this account was used in a lateral movement context suggests potential compromise or misuse. This is why it is flagged as critical.
- `src_ip: 10.0.0.20` and `dst_ip: 10.0.0.25`: While these IPs are not flagged as critical in the answer key, they still provide context. Understanding the network topology and the roles of the machines involved can help analysts determine if this behavior is typical or indicative of malicious activity. In this case, both IPs are internal, which could suggest legitimate administrative actions if not for the suspicious context.

Verdict Reasoning

The verdict of true positive is supported by the combination of the critical artifact (the use of the admin_user account) and the context of lateral movement via PSExec. If the username had been a standard user account, it could have led to a false positive, as legitimate administrative tasks might not raise alarms. However, the specific use of an admin account in this context, especially with the potential for PSExec to be abused, solidifies the conclusion that this is indeed a true positive.

Why These Response Actions

- `isolate_host`: This action is crucial because the source host (10.0.0.20) may already be compromised. Isolating it prevents further lateral movement within the network while we investigate the incident.
- `reset_credentials`: Given that an admin account was involved, it s essential to reset the credentials for `admin_user` to prevent any further unauthorized access. This action mitigates the risk of the attacker maintaining access.
- `collect_forensics`: This is necessary to understand the extent of the compromise. By collecting forensic data, we can analyze what processes were executed, what files were accessed, and whether any data was exfiltrated. This helps in determining the blast radius and informs our incident response strategy.

Analyst Pro Tips

1. Understand the Role of Accounts: Always consider the privileges associated with the account involved in suspicious activities. Elevated privileges can indicate a higher risk of compromise.
2. Context is Key: Analyze the context of the actions. Lateral movement with administrative accounts should always raise alarms, whereas similar

... (truncated — full walkthrough at infoseclabs.io)